

“The **whole public are tired out** with these **annual, autumnal outbreaks** [of election violence] in the South.”

PRESIDENT GRANT TO ATTORNEY GENERAL EDWARD PIERREPONT,
SEPTEMBER 1875

Contested election

The hinge point in bringing Reconstruction to a close was the presidential election of 1876. The two candidates were Governor Rutherford B. Hayes of Ohio for the Republicans and New York Governor Samuel J. Tilden for the Democrats. With little public interest any longer in the old war issues, the need for government reform was both parties' central message. Both candidates had genuine reform credentials, but it was unclear what Hayes intended to do about the South, since his platform called for conflicting notions of “permanent pacification” and protection of equal rights.

By this time, the Democratic Party once more controlled most Southern states, the exceptions being South Carolina, Florida, and Louisiana. There were widespread outbreaks of violence in the South during the election, and these stifled Republican voters, although to an unknown degree. Tilden had a small lead in the popular national vote, but the votes were contested, and accusations of fraud were aimed at both sides. The result was uncertainty about who the next president would be, which threatened to continue well into 1877.

In the end, an Electoral Commission set up to resolve the issue declared the Republican Hayes the winner, but the result was unsatisfactory since Republicans narrowly dominated the commission. Democratic opposition only ended with a backroom deal between Southern Democrats and representatives of Hayes.